

# NĀṬYASĀSTRĀ GURUKULAM

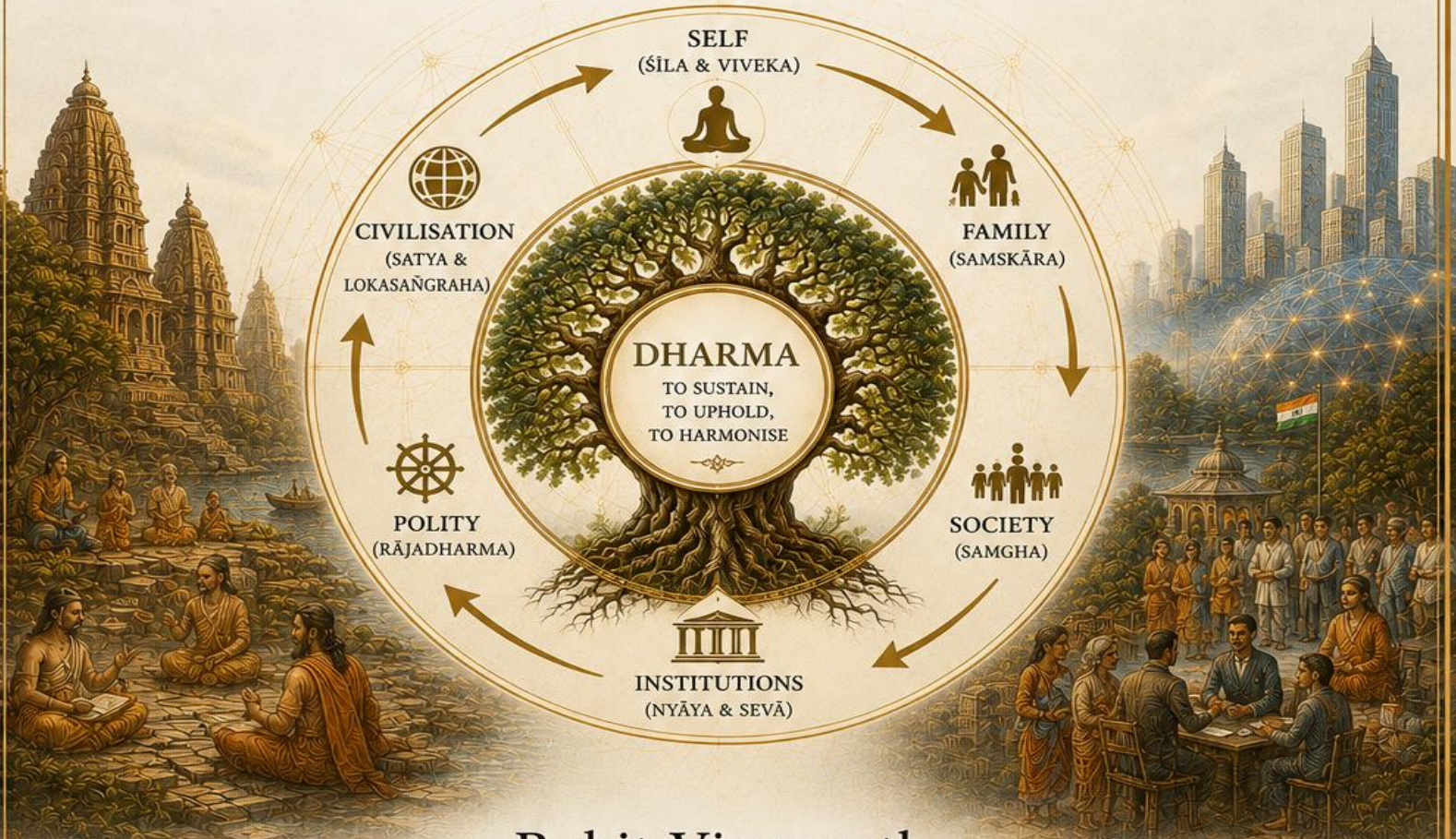
Centre for Civilisational Statecraft

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## DHARMA

### FROM DISCIPLINE TO PARTICIPATION

A CIVILISATIONAL THEORY OF SUSTENANCE



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*Dharmo viśvasya jagataḥ pratiṣṭhā*

Dharma is the foundation of the entire universe.

## Abstract

Modern discussions routinely reduce *dharma* to duty, ethics, religion, or law. Classical Indian thought presents a richer architecture. This paper argues that *dharma* possesses a two-level structure. At the first level, *dharma* functions as a framework of self-discipline, limitation, and character formation through which the individual becomes fit for higher knowledge. At the second level, it operates as a mode of participatory and contributory stewardship through which individuals consciously sustain social, institutional, and civilisational order.

This architecture illuminates how individual discipline matures into civic participation (*lokasaṅgraha*), is reproduced culturally through *Nāṭya*, and finds political expression in *Dharma Rājyam*. Read in this manner, *dharma* emerges not merely as a system of norms or obligations but as a civilisational principle of sustenance linking self-cultivation, cultural formation, institutional legitimacy, and political order.



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## 1. Introduction: The Puzzle of Dharma

If the ultimate aim of human life is liberation (*mokṣa*), why does *dharma* remain significant after knowledge is attained? This question has occupied the Indian intellectual tradition across its philosophical, theological, and political dimensions. The classical sources repeatedly present figures who have attained the highest knowledge and yet continue to act within the world.

Rāma, the legendary king of Ayodhya, remains actively engaged in governance despite embodying a level of wisdom and self-transcendence that could have justified withdrawal from worldly affairs. Bharata serves as regent during Rāma's exile, treating authority as a sacred trust rather than a personal possession. Janaka continues to rule despite being celebrated as a *jīvanmukta*. Kṛṣṇa, who stands beyond all obligation, nevertheless acts continuously and exhorts others to do the same. Sages such as Yājñavalka continue to teach after attaining self-knowledge. In each case, liberation does not culminate in withdrawal. Knowledge appears not to terminate action but to transform its meaning.

Why does the liberated person continue to act? What remains of *dharma* once the ordinary motivations of desire, fear, obligation, and social expectation have been transcended? These questions point toward a deeper understanding of *dharma* than is typically available through its modern translations.

### 1.1. The Problem of Translation

Few concepts within the Indian intellectual tradition have travelled as widely and been understood as imperfectly as *dharma*. Modern scholarship and public discourse frequently render *dharma* as religion, law, ethics, morality, virtue, custom, or duty. Each translation captures an aspect of the concept, yet none adequately conveys its full scope.

Religion suggests adherence to a creed or confessional system of belief. Law implies enforceable rules backed by political authority. Ethics emphasises personal virtue and moral judgment. Duty evokes obligations attached to particular offices or roles. *Dharma* includes elements of all these meanings while remaining reducible to none of them.

The difficulty is not merely linguistic. Translation inevitably shapes interpretation. When *dharma* is translated primarily as religion, it appears sectarian. When translated as law, it appears juridical. When rendered as morality, it appears individualistic. Each translation obscures the wider systemic and civilisational dimensions that enabled *dharma* to function as one of the central organising concepts of Indian thought.

## 1.2. The Central Thesis

This paper seeks to recover *dharma* as a civilisational concept. Rather than approaching the subject through contemporary political controversy or ideological appropriation, it returns to the conceptual architecture developed within the orthodox traditions.

The argument advanced here is that *dharma* possesses a two-level structure. At the first level, it functions as a framework of self-discipline, restraint, proportion, and character formation. At the second level, it becomes a mode of conscious participation through which individuals, institutions, and communities contribute to the sustenance of social and cosmic order.

The framework presented in this paper is not claimed as a single doctrinal formulation explicitly articulated in any one classical source. Rather, it is a synthetic reconstruction derived from recurring patterns that appear across the *Dharmaśāstra*, *Vedānta*, *Bhagavad Gītā*, *Nāṭyaśāstra*, and *Rājadharmā* traditions. The objective is not historical reduction but conceptual clarification. By bringing these strands into conversation, the paper seeks to illuminate an underlying architecture that connects self-cultivation, civic participation, cultural formation, and political order.

*Dharma begins as discipline but culminates in participation; its highest purpose is not merely to regulate conduct, but to sustain order.*

## 1.3. The Two-Level Architecture

The paper proposes that *dharma* operates through two interconnected levels:

Level One: Self-Discipline — At the first level, *dharma* functions as a discipline of self-formation through which individuals cultivate restraint, proportion, responsibility, and

fitness for higher knowledge. Its purpose is not obedience for its own sake, but preparation. Through ethical discipline and role-specific responsibility, the human personality is refined and rendered capable of deeper understanding and self-transcendence.

Level Two: Participation and Contribution— At the second level, *dharma* becomes conscious participation in the maintenance of social and cosmic order. Action is no longer driven primarily by desire, fear, or obligation. It becomes custodial, sustaining, and participatory. The realised individual acts not to acquire fulfilment but from fulfilment, voluntarily contributing to the preservation of family, community, institutions, civilisation, and ultimately *lokasaṅgraha*, the holding together of the world..

The transition between these two levels is mediated by knowledge (*jñāna*) and detached action (*niṣkāma karma*).

#### 1.4. How This Paper Proceeds

The argument unfolds in nine stages. Section Two establishes *dharma* as the principle that sustains. Section Three examines the first level of *dharma* through the categories of *Sāmānya dharma*, *Viśeṣa dharma*, *Svadharmā*, *Rājadharmā* and *Śreṣṭha Dharma*. Section Four explains how self-discipline prepares the mind for knowledge through *citta-śuddhi* and *adhikāra*. Section Five serves as the conceptual hinge, examining the transformation of action after knowledge through the idea of *lokasaṅgraha*.

Section Six develops the notion of participatory *dharma*. Section Seven explores *Nāṭya* as the primary cultural mechanism through which participatory dispositions are reproduced within society. Section Eight examines the cosmic dimension of participation through the concept of *līlā*. Section Nine traces the scaling of *dharma* from personal cultivation to political order through the idea of *Dharma Rājyam*. The conclusion synthesises these strands into a civilisational theory of order.

#### 1.5. Why This Matters

Contemporary societies increasingly confront challenges of fragmentation, declining trust, institutional erosion, civic disengagement, and crises of legitimacy. The *dhārmic* tradition

does not offer a ready-made blueprint for resolving these problems, nor does it provide a programme for restoring pre-modern institutions. Its contribution lies elsewhere.

*Dharma* directs attention toward the sustaining conditions that precede formal rules and political mechanisms. It suggests that enduring social order depends not only upon procedures and enforcement but also upon character, restraint, responsibility, participation, and cultural formation. These concerns remain as relevant today as they were in classical times. In contemporary terms, *dharma* may be viewed as a theory of civilisational viability concerned with the preservation of those conditions that allow societies to remain coherent, legitimate, and adaptive across generations.

## 2. Dharma as the Principle that Sustains

The Sanskrit root *dhṛ* means ‘to uphold’, ‘to sustain’. ‘to support’, or ‘to bear’. This etymology is not merely lexical; it reveals the conceptual orientation of *dharma* within the Indian intellectual tradition. *Dharma* is fundamentally concerned with the conditions that enable continuity, stability, and flourishing across individual, social, and cosmic domains.<sup>1</sup>

Classical formulations express this sustaining character succinctly. The traditional maxim *dhārayati iti dharmah* (‘that which sustains is *dharma*’) emphasises its preservative function. Likewise, *dharmo rakṣati rakṣitaḥ* (‘*dharma* protects those who protect it’) highlights the reciprocal relationship between sustaining order and being sustained by it.

To understand *dharma* merely as a set of duties or moral injunctions is therefore to mistake one of its manifestations for its deeper function. The primary concern of *dharma* is not regulation for its own sake but sustenance. It names those principles, practices, and dispositions that enable a system to endure without degenerating into disorder.

The earliest Vedic vision of order is articulated through the concept of *ṛta*. *Ṛta* denotes the underlying regularity and intelligibility of existence: the cyclical movement of the seasons,

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<sup>1</sup> Pandurang Vaman Kane, *History of Dharmaśāstra*, vol. 1 (Poona: Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute, 1968), 1–10.



the reliability of natural processes, the coherence of ritual action, and the ordered structure of the cosmos itself.<sup>2</sup>

In the Vedic imagination, order is not imposed externally upon a chaotic universe. Rather, order is intrinsic to reality. The cosmos possesses an inherent pattern that makes meaningful action possible. *Dharma* emerges historically as the practical and human articulation of this cosmic principle. If *ṛta* describes the order of reality itself, *dharma* describes the manner in which human beings participate in, preserve, and transmit that order within lived existence.

This relationship is significant because it distinguishes the *dhārmic* conception of order from many modern accounts. Order is not viewed merely as a political achievement generated by state power, nor solely as a contractual arrangement among self-interested individuals. It is understood as participation in a pre-existing reality whose coherence must be recognised and sustained.

2.1. Dharma as a Multi-Level Principle of Sustenance

| Level      | What Dharma Sustains                            | Representative Expressions                  |
|------------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Individual | Character and self-mastery                      | Truthfulness, restraint, integrity          |
| Family     | Relationships and inter-generational continuity | Care, obligation, fidelity, nurturing       |
| Social     | Trust and reciprocity                           | Compassion, fairness, mutual responsibility |

<sup>2</sup> Anima Sen Gupta, *Essays on Sāṃkhya and Other Systems of Indian Philosophy* (Patna: United Press, 1964), 34–42; Arthur Anthony Macdonell, *Vedic Mythology* (Strassburg: Karl J. Trübner, 1897), 11–14.

|               |                              |                                                                    |
|---------------|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Institutional | Legitimacy and role fidelity | Judicial integrity, pedagogical trust, professional ethics         |
| Political     | Order and equilibrium        | <i>Rājadharmā</i> , constitutional restraint, custodial governance |

*Dharma* thus operates as a multi-level architecture of sustenance, extending from the formation of individual character through family and social relationships to the legitimacy of institutions and the stability of political order.

At the individual level, *dharma* sustains character, preventing the personality from fragmenting under the pressure of desire and impulse. At the social level, *dharma* sustains trust. Human cooperation depends upon expectations of honesty, reciprocity, and reliability. Where these disappear, social life becomes dominated by suspicion and strategic manipulation.

At the institutional level, *dharma* sustains legitimacy. Institutions remain viable not merely because they possess legal authority but because they command confidence. Courts, schools, universities, professions, and administrative bodies depend upon role fidelity and ethical integrity.

At the political level, *dharma* sustains order. Political power is directed toward preserving the conditions under which individual flourishing and collective life remain possible. Governance ceases to be merely an exercise of authority and becomes a custodial responsibility.

## 2.2. Why Dharma Resists Translation

The persistent difficulty of translating *dharma* arises because modern categories divide functions that the classical tradition treated as interconnected. *Dharma* contains elements

that modern discourse would classify separately as religion, law, ethics, virtue, duty, custom, and civic responsibility. Yet it exceeds each category.<sup>3</sup>

Religion typically refers to belief, creed, or confessional affiliation. *Dharma* is not primarily organised around belief but around participation in sustaining order. Law refers to rules enforced by sovereign authority. *Dharma* precedes and judges political authority rather than deriving from it.

*Dharma* is neither religion-specific nor nation-specific. While articulated through different cultural and civilisational forms, its underlying concern with sustaining life, order, responsibility, and flourishing possesses a fundamentally universal character. Its scope extends beyond any particular creed, community, or political boundary.

This distinction has important implications for modern political discourse. Secularism may be more accurately understood as *pantha nirapekṣatā* (non-preference among paths or traditions) rather than *dharma nirapekṣatā*. Since *dharma* denotes the sustaining principles of ethical, social, and civic order, a society cannot be indifferent to *dharma* without undermining the very conditions of its own coherence. What secular governance requires is impartiality among competing paths (*panthas*), not indifference to *dharma* itself.

The challenge of translation therefore reflects a deeper conceptual difference. *Dharma* is not a specialised sphere of life alongside politics, morality, and culture. Rather, it functions as an integrating principle linking all of them together.

### 2.3. Dharma and Systemic Viability

Viewed through this lens, *dharma* may be understood as a theory of systemic viability. A civilisation survives not merely because it possesses laws, armies, markets, or administrative machinery. It survives because individuals exercise restraint, communities cultivate trust, institutions maintain legitimacy, and political authority remains bounded by higher norms. These sustaining conditions often remain invisible until they begin to erode.

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<sup>3</sup> Wilhelm Halbfass, *India and Europe: An Essay in Understanding* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1988), 325–43.

When they collapse, societies experience fragmentation, declining trust, institutional decay, and crises of legitimacy.

### 3. The First Level of Dharma: Self- Discipline

At its first level, *dharma* functions as self- discipline. This discipline is often misunderstood as a system of external commands imposed upon individuals by society, scripture, or political authority. Such an interpretation is incomplete. Within the classical tradition, discipline is not an end in itself. Its purpose is formative rather than punitive.<sup>4</sup>

The aim of Level One *dharma* is the cultivation of a human being capable of self-mastery. It seeks to shape character, regulate desire, moderate power, and establish the internal order necessary for higher knowledge. The individual who practices *dharma* is not being conditioned for obedience but prepared for freedom.

#### 3.1. Sāmānya Dharma: The Universal Ethical Foundation

The first layer of disciplinary *dharma* is *Sāmānya Dharma*, the set of ethical dispositions regarded as universally applicable across distinctions of status, occupation, region, or historical circumstance.<sup>5</sup> These include *Satya* (truthfulness), *Ahiṃsā* (non-injury), *Asteya* (non-stealing), *Dayā* (compassion), *Sama* (restraint of the senses), *Kṣamā* (forbearance), and *Ārjava* (uprightness).

#### 3.2. Viśeṣa Dharma: Context and Practical Wisdom

Universal principles alone cannot govern the complexity of lived reality. The tradition therefore supplements universal norms with *Viśeṣa Dharma*, context-sensitive judgment.<sup>6</sup> *Viśeṣa Dharma* recognises that sustaining order often requires practical wisdom rather than rigid rule application. This flexibility should not be confused with moral relativism; contextual judgment remains oriented toward the sustaining purpose of *dharma*.

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<sup>4</sup> Patrick Olivelle, *The Law Codes of Āpastamba, Gautama, Baudhāyana, and Vasiṣṭha* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000), 42–51.

<sup>5</sup> Ibid, 45.

<sup>6</sup> Robert Lingat, *The Classical Law of India*, trans. J. Duncan M. Derrett (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1973), 67–74.

### 3.3. Svadharma: Responsibility and Differentiated Function

The third layer of disciplinary *dharma* is *Svadharma*, one's own *dharma*. Human beings occupy different positions within social life and possess different capacities, dispositions, and responsibilities.<sup>7</sup> Society is compared to an organic whole whose stability depends upon differentiated but coordinated activity. *Svadharma* serves as an education in custodianship, where the individual learns to understand their work as a contribution to the maintenance of a larger order.

### 3.4. Rājadharmā: The Discipline of Power

The highest and most demanding form of disciplinary *dharma* concerns political authority. The *dhārmic* answer to preventing arbitrary power is *Rājadharmā*.<sup>8</sup> Unlike theories that regard sovereignty as fundamentally unrestricted, the classical Indian tradition consistently places the ruler under *dharma*. Power becomes limited by obligations rather than justified by entitlement.

### 3.5. Śreṣṭha Dharma: From Obligation to Exemplarity

Classical traditions also recognise the idea of *Śreṣṭha Dharma*, the higher or noblest expression of *dharma*. While ordinary discussions of *dharma* often focus on duties, obligations, and role-specific responsibilities, *Śreṣṭha Dharma* refers to conduct guided by wisdom, selflessness, and concern for the welfare of the larger whole.

The *Bhagavad Gītā* emphasises that the conduct of exemplary individuals shapes the conduct of society: 'Whatever the best among people does, others follow.' The significance of *Śreṣṭha Dharma* therefore lies not merely in personal virtue but in its formative influence upon collective life. Such individuals become living standards through which *dharma* is embodied, interpreted, and transmitted.

Rāma, Bharata, Janaka, and Kṛṣṇa are remembered within the tradition not simply because they fulfilled obligations but because they transformed obligation into custodial

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<sup>7</sup> Mysore Hiriyanna, *Outlines of Indian Philosophy* (London: George Allen & Unwin, 1932), 118–24.

<sup>8</sup> John W. Spellman, *Political Theory of Ancient India: A Study of Kingship from the Earliest Times to Śaṅkara* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1964), 98–105.



stewardship. Their actions illustrate how *dharma*, when matured through knowledge and self-mastery, becomes participation in the preservation of social and civilisational order.

#### 4. Dharma as Preparation for Knowledge

The first level of *dharma* forms part of a larger developmental sequence that links conduct, character, knowledge, and liberation: *Dharma* → *Citta-śuddhi* → *Adhikāra* → *Jñāna* → *Mokṣa*. Knowledge is treated as a mode of direct insight into reality, which requires a properly prepared instrument.<sup>9</sup>

##### 4.1. The Human Problem: Distortion Rather Than Ignorance Alone

The deeper problem is distortion. Human beings perceive reality through a mind shaped by attachment, aversion, fear, ambition, and habitual identification with the ego.<sup>10</sup> The obstacle to knowledge is not merely lack of information but the condition of the knower.

##### 4.2. Citta-Śuddhi: Purification of the Inner Instrument

The first major fruit of *dharma* is *citta-śuddhi*. *Citta* refers to the inner field of consciousness comprising thought, memory, perception, and affective disposition. *Śuddhi* denotes purification, refinement, or clarification. Together, *citta-śuddhi* signifies the progressive refinement of consciousness that prepares the individual for higher knowledge.

Just as a dusty mirror cannot accurately reflect what stands before it, a mind clouded by selfish desire cannot clearly perceive reality. *Dharma* gradually removes these distortions. Truthfulness reduces self-deception; compassion weakens ego-centredness; self-restraint moderates impulsiveness. Classical traditions explain this process through the concept of *vāsanā* (habitual tendencies). Repeated actions leave enduring impressions on the mind and gradually shape character. *Dharma* therefore functions not merely through isolated acts of virtue but through the cultivation of dispositions that make virtuous action increasingly natural and spontaneous.

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<sup>9</sup> Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan, *The Principal Upaniṣads* (London: George Allen & Unwin, 1953), 45–52.

<sup>10</sup> Eliot Deutsch, *Advaita Vedānta: A Philosophical Reconstruction* (Honolulu: University Press of Hawaii, 1973), 95–102.

### 4.3. Adhikāra/Yogyatā: Fitness for Higher Knowledge

The result of *citta-śuddhi* is *adhikāra* or *yogyatā*, namely, fitness, qualification, or readiness. A person becomes qualified for higher knowledge because they possess the interior stability required to assimilate transformative insight, such as discrimination (*viveka*) and detachment (*vairāgya*).

Classical expositions frequently emphasise that *dharma* occupies a unique position among the *puruṣārthas*. While it may initially support the pursuit of material well-being and social order, its deeper purpose lies in preparing the individual for liberation. The same practices that sustain civic and ethical life simultaneously cultivate the inner maturity required for higher knowledge.

### 4.4. Why Ethics and Metaphysics Cannot Be Separated

The classical *dhārmic* traditions generally refuse the separation of ethics and metaphysics. Knowledge depends upon the condition of the knower. A fragmented mind cannot apprehend unity. Ethics therefore becomes the ground upon which metaphysical insight rests.

## 5. Knowledge and the Problem of Continuing Action

If the purpose of *dharma* is fulfilled through knowledge, why should action continue at all? The answer marks the decisive transition between the two levels of *dharma*: knowledge does not abolish action; it transforms its basis.

Prior to realisation, action functions as acquisition (one acts in order to become). The realised individual stands in an entirely different relationship to action: because inner completeness has already been discovered, action no longer serves a compensatory function. The liberated person acts not to achieve fulfilment, but from fulfilment.<sup>11</sup>

The *Gītā* introduces action performed without attachment to personal gain.<sup>12</sup> Kṛṣṇa declares that although he lacks nothing and has no unmet obligation, he nevertheless

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<sup>11</sup> Arvind Sharma, *The Puruṣārthas: A Study in Hindu Axiology* (East Lansing: Michigan State University Press, 1982), 29–37.

<sup>12</sup> Sri Aurobindo, *Essays on the Gītā* (Pondicherry: Sri Aurobindo Ashram, 1970), 123–34.

remains engaged in action. The centre of gravity shifts from self-concern to participation and contribution.

The term *lokasaṅgraha* combines *loka* and *saṅgraha*. *Loka* refers to the world, the people, or the sphere of collective life. *Saṅgraha* means holding together, sustaining, preserving, or integrating. *Lokasaṅgraha* therefore signifies the conscious maintenance of the conditions that enable collective life to flourish.

As a civic and civilisational ideal, *lokasaṅgraha* represents the first mature expression of participatory *dharma*.<sup>13</sup> The realised person recognises that social and civilisational orders are not self-sustaining and require continual renewal. Participation in sustaining those conditions becomes a natural expression of wisdom rather than an externally imposed obligation.

After realisation, what was previously experienced as duty becomes participation. The individual does not abandon *dharma*; the individual becomes an embodiment of *dharma*. This internal consistency means that external scriptural injunctions cease to act as coercive commands, turning instead into organic and spontaneous descriptions of the realised individual's behaviour.

## 6. The Second Level of Dharma: Participatory and Contributory Dharma

Participatory and contributory *dharma* represents the fulfilment of disciplinary *dharma*. The structures of restraint, responsibility, and self-limitation cultivated at the first level become internalised and transformed into a spontaneous commitment to sustaining the larger order.

### 6.1. What Participatory and Contributory Dharma Is Not

It is not mere compliance with rules, nor conventional duty, nor utilitarian calculation, nor simple self-expression. It arises from the recognition that one's life is inseparable from wider networks of social, institutional, ecological, and cosmic interdependence.

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<sup>13</sup> Ibid.

## 6.2. Custodial Participation

The practitioner of participatory and contributory *dharma* understands themselves as a trustee or steward within an inherited order whose continuity depends upon responsible action. The teacher transmits knowledge because knowledge must endure; the judge protects justice because justice sustains trust.

Participatory *dharma* shifts attention from entitlement toward custodianship. It asks what responsibilities sustain the conditions under which rights can meaningfully exist.

## 6.3. Order Maintained from Within

The stability of social systems ultimately depends upon dispositions that cannot themselves be legislated into existence. Participatory *dharma* suggests that enduring order arises not merely from external control but from cultivated forms of inward responsibility. Freedom reaches its highest expression not in isolation but in participation and contribution.

## 7. Nāṭya as the Social Reproduction of Dharma

How does a society transmit not merely information but character? The classical Indian tradition addresses this question through *Nāṭya*, the tradition of drama, performance, and the embodied arts. In the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, *Nāṭya* is not treated as mere entertainment but as a public and universal art capable of communicating meaning across social divisions and helping to articulate the normative life of the community. Its status as a ‘fifth Veda’ underscores this seriousness: it is an art intended to be accessible, instructive, and civilisational in scope.<sup>14</sup>

*Nāṭya* functions as a bridge between individual formation and social order, but it does so through aesthetic transformation rather than direct moral instruction. Bharata’s theory does not simply catalogue emotions; it shows how dramatic presentation structures a shared field of experience in which human feeling becomes publicly intelligible. The performance is not valuable only because it represents action. It is valuable because it

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<sup>14</sup> Bharata Muni, *Nāṭyaśāstra*, trans. Adya Rangacharya (New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1996), 1.14–18.

renders action, emotion, and consequence available to contemplation in a disciplined form.<sup>15</sup>

### 7.1. From Bhāva to Rasa: The Refinement of Emotion

The core of this theory lies in the transformation of *bhāva* into *rasa*. *Bhāva* denotes the manifest emotional state or dramatic presentation, while *rasa* is the aesthetic relish or delight that arises when that state is properly received by the spectator. The spectator does not merely observe emotion from a distance, nor does the spectator sink into private identification with it. Instead, the emotional situation is aesthetically transfigured into an experience that is at once intimate and universal.<sup>16</sup>

Abhinavagupta's *Abhinavabhāratī* gives this account its most subtle philosophical form. For Abhinava, *rasa* arises through *sādhārāṇīkaraṇa*, universalisation. This is the process by which the specific markers of ordinary personal experience are suspended so that emotion can be enjoyed in a generalised and depersonalised mode. The spectator does not say, 'this is my grief' or 'this is my courage,' but experiences grief, courage, wonder, or compassion as shared human possibility. In political terms, aesthetic universalisation reduces the tendency of pluralistic societies to collapse disagreement into existential antagonism. By momentarily suspending narrow ego-identification, it enables citizens to encounter conflict, suffering, aspiration, and difference as elements of a shared human condition rather than as irreconcilable divisions. *Rasa* depends on this depersonalisation: it is not imitation alone, but a transformed mode of participation in feeling.<sup>17</sup>

This is why Abhinava also insists that *rasa* involves a distinctive form of consciousness. The aesthetic subject is neither fully immersed in practical life nor detached in a merely abstract sense. Rather, the spectator participates without possessiveness, feels without appropriation, and knows without ordinary utilitarian concern. In that respect, aesthetic

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<sup>15</sup> Kapila Vatsyayan, *The Square and the Circle of the Indian Arts* (New Delhi: Abhinav Publications, 1983), 17–26.

<sup>16</sup> Bharata Muni, *Nāṭyaśāstra*, chap. 6; Gnoli, trans., *The Aesthetic Experience According to Abhinavagupta* (Varanasi: Chowkhamba Sanskrit Series, 1968), 52–59.

<sup>17</sup> Abhinavagupta, *Abhinavabhāratī*, in Gnoli, *The Aesthetic Experience According to Abhinavagupta*, 59–71.

experience becomes a training in non-egocentric participation. Emotion is not suppressed; it is refined into a contemplative mode.<sup>18</sup>

The deeper philosophical significance of *Nāṭya* emerges from a broader *dhārmic* understanding of worldly existence as a form of *līlā*, a participatory drama through which individuals encounter responsibility, consequence, and self-realisation.<sup>19</sup> Existence is not conceived as a collection of isolated individuals pursuing private ends, but as a shared drama governed by relationships, obligations, and consequences. Each person participates through the performance of a situated *dharma*, occupying particular roles and responsibilities just as each dramatic character contributes to the coherence of a larger narrative whole. *Nāṭya* therefore serves not merely as entertainment or instruction but as a symbolic representation of the structure of reality itself. By witnessing and participating in dramatic action, individuals learn to perceive their own lives as embedded within a larger moral and social order whose stability depends upon the harmonious performance of differentiated roles.

Seen from this perspective, *Nāṭya* helps reproduce the conditions of social life not simply by representing norms but by cultivating the dispositions that make shared life possible. It cultivates proportion, empathy, restraint, and attentiveness to consequence. Political institutions may regulate conduct, but they cannot by themselves generate the deeper affective habits through which persons inhabit a common world. *Nāṭya* contributes to that task by forming spectators who can receive powerful emotion without being mastered by it, and performers who can embody feeling without collapsing into it.<sup>20</sup>

Classical commentators therefore understood *Nāṭya* not merely as artistic expression but as a civilisational institution. It operates in the space between law and private conscience, shaping the dispositions through which individuals become capable of participating in a

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<sup>18</sup> Ibid., 71–78.

<sup>19</sup> Ananda K. Coomaraswamy, *The Dance of Śiva: Essays on Indian Art and Culture* (New York: Noonday Press, 1957), 56–66.

<sup>20</sup> Kapila Vatsyayan, *Introduction to the Study of the Nāṭyaśāstra* (New Delhi: Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts, 1996), 45–53.



common normative order. Where formal institutions regulate behaviour externally, *Nāṭya* works internally through imagination, emotion, and reflection.

In this sense, *Nāṭya* is not merely a cultural supplement to civic life. It is one of the media through which participatory order is socially reproduced. By universalising emotion and turning it into *rasa*, it cultivates a public world in which human beings learn to share meaning without reducing it to private possession. That is why the aesthetic theory of Bharata and Abhinava can be read as a profound account of cultural formation: it explains how a civilisation transmits across generations the dispositions necessary for *dhārmic* participation, namely feeling, judgment, self-command, and reciprocal understanding.

## 8. *Līlā* and the Cosmic Dimension of Participation

The sustaining order in which human beings participate is itself embedded within a larger cosmic reality. If *lokasaṅgraha* represents the civic expression of participatory *dharma*, *līlā* represents its cosmic consummation.<sup>21</sup>

The term *līlā* is commonly understood as play, sport, or spontaneous expression. In philosophical usage, it signifies action arising from fullness rather than necessity. Creation itself comes to be viewed not as a response to need but as an expression of abundance.

Both *lokasaṅgraha* and *līlā* presuppose a fundamental shift in the basis of action: fulfilment precedes activity, participation replaces self-centred striving, and action becomes detached from acquisition. *Lokasaṅgraha* operates within the civic domain, while *līlā* extends the same principle into the cosmic domain.<sup>22</sup> One does not invoke *līlā* as an excuse for abandoning civic responsibility; rather, *līlā* reveals its deepest ontological ground.

At the highest level, action is no longer experienced as a burden or duty; it becomes effortless participation. The individual acts because action expresses their understanding

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<sup>21</sup> Ananda K. Coomaraswamy, *Hinduism and Buddhism* (New York: Philosophical Library, 1943), 67–74.

<sup>22</sup> Sri Aurobindo, *The Life Divine* (Pondicherry: Sri Aurobindo Ashram, 1970), 879–92.

of reality.<sup>23</sup> Genuine freedom culminates in responsible participation rather than withdrawal.

The aesthetic distance cultivated through *Nāṭya* mirrors, at a lower level, the witness consciousness cultivated through realisation.<sup>24</sup> In both cases, participation becomes possible without attachment, preparing the imagination to perceive reality itself as participatory.

## 9. Dharma Rājya: The Political Expression of Participatory Dharma

What form of political order corresponds to this civilisational architecture? The answer proposed by the classical tradition is *Dharma Rājya*. It is best understood as the political expression of participatory *dharma*, focused on the preservation of the conditions necessary for individual flourishing, social trust, institutional legitimacy, and civic participation.<sup>25</sup>

### 9.1. The Political Problem

Every political order must resolve how power can be exercised without degenerating into domination. The *dhārmic* response is that political order is ultimately unsustainable unless supported by deeper processes of civic formation.<sup>26</sup> The health of a polity rests upon the character of the people who inhabit its institutions.

### 9.2. The State as Custodian Rather Than Sovereign Owner

The central political principle of *Dharma Rājya* is custodianship.<sup>27</sup> Political authority remains subordinate to *dharma*; the ruler becomes a trustee rather than a proprietor, and office becomes responsibility rather than entitlement. Legitimacy depends upon fidelity to the sustaining purposes of *dharma*.

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<sup>23</sup> Raimon Panikkar, *The Vedic Experience: Mantramañjari* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1977), 112–19.

<sup>24</sup> Ananda K. Coomaraswamy, “Līlā,” in *Selected Papers: Metaphysics*, ed. Roger Lipsey (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1977), 147–54.

<sup>25</sup> The present treatment builds upon an earlier exploration of *Rāma Rājya* developed as part of the *Tattvaloka* “Onward March to Rāma Rājya” campaign. See [Rāma Rājya Campaign Website](#).

<sup>26</sup> Kane, *History of Dharmasāstra*, vol. 3 (Poona: Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute, 1973), 35–52.

<sup>27</sup> Spellman, *Political Theory of Ancient India*, 98–116.

### 9.3. Dharma Rājyam and Constitutional Order

*Dharma Rājyam* complements constitutional order by directing attention toward the cultural and ethical conditions that enable constitutional systems to endure.<sup>28</sup> Constitutions establish procedures, but they cannot by themselves generate civic virtue or trust. The framework addresses how citizens must be formed to sustain those structures.

### 9.4. Distinguishing Dharma Rājyam from Other Political Models

- Liberal Constitutionalism: Focuses on rights and procedural safeguards. *Dharma Rājyam* values these achievements but adds an explicit emphasis on the cultivation of civic responsibility.
- Theocracy: Derives legitimacy from religious or clerical authority. *Dharma Rājyam* is concerned with the preservation of sustaining order rather than theological conformity.
- Civic Republicanism: Emphasises public virtue. *Dharma Rājyam* shares this but grounds it within a broader metaphysical and civilisational framework.
- Majoritarian Nationalism: *Dharma Rājyam's* legitimacy derives from adherence to sustaining principles rather than demographic or numerical strength.

A stable political order requires what may be called Disciplined Equilibrium: a careful balance among individual freedom, social responsibility, institutional authority, civic participation, and cultural continuity. *Dharma* sustains by preserving this balance, so governance becomes an ongoing act of custodial adjustment rather than ideological imposition. Political stability emerges not from coercion alone but from civic maturity. In this sense, *Dharma Rājyam* names a political order sustained from within, where legitimacy rests on character, trust, and responsible participation rather than external compulsion.

## 10. Conclusion: Dharma as a Civilisational Architecture of Sustenance

The central argument of this paper has been that *dharma* is most adequately understood not as a rule system but as a principle of sustenance. *Dharma* operates simultaneously across individual, social, institutional, political, and cosmic domains. The same practices

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<sup>28</sup> Bimal Krishna Matilal, *The Moral Dilemmas of Law in Indian Philosophy* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1998), 22–31.

that cultivate personal discipline also generate trust, sustain institutions, support political order, and prepare the individual for higher realisation. *Dharma* therefore functions not as a specialised domain of life but as a unifying principle linking ethical formation, civic participation, and spiritual development. Its function in each case is fundamentally one of sustenance: the cultivation of character, the preservation of trust, the maintenance of legitimacy, and the stabilisation of order. Its concern is not merely correct conduct but the preservation of the conditions that make flourishing possible.

The paper has proposed a two-level architecture. At the first level, *dharma* functions as self-discipline, cultivating self-mastery, responsibility, and restraint. This process culminates in *citta-śuddhi* and *adhikāra*, preparing the individual for transformative insight. The attainment of knowledge introduces the concept of *lokasaṅgraha*, where action is reconstituted as stewardship. This transition marks the emergence of the second level: participatory and contributory *dharma*, a mode of custodial engagement where the individual consciously contributes to the whole.

Because no civilisation can rely exclusively upon exceptional individuals, these participatory dispositions must be reproduced culturally. This task is performed by *Nāṭya*, which through *rasa* and *sādhāraṇīkaraṇa* refines emotion and universalises experience, converting private feeling into shared civilisational capacity. The concept of *līlā* expands this principle to its widest cosmic horizon, providing the ontological ground upon which stewardship rests.

These insights culminate in *Dharma Rājyam*, a social order sustained from within. Contemporary societies confronting crises of trust, institutional erosion, and civic fragmentation cannot resolve these challenges solely through procedural reform. The *dhārmic* tradition reminds us that stable institutions depend upon disciplined individuals, legitimate authority depends upon civic trust, and durable political order depends upon the cultural reproduction of participatory dispositions. *Dharma*, in this sense, names the sustaining processes through which civilisations preserve themselves across generations.

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